Shows Like 'Cops' Fell Out of Favor. Now Texas May Ban Them.

Lawmakers passed a bill named for Javier Ambler II, who died in 2019 after officers arrested him in front of a "Live PD" television crew. If the governor signs it, this would mean the end of police cooperation with reality TV shows.

Two years ago, a television crew gathered in the small city of Hawkins, Texas, to film the life and work of Manfred Gilow, the chief of police there.

Cameras followed Chief Gilow as he and his officers responded to calls, snapped handcuffs onto wrists and searched vehicles for drugs. The program was not available on Texas televisions; Chief Gilow is from Germany, and that is where "Der Germinator" (a portmanteau of "German" and "The Terminator") was broadcast.

Last year, after the nationally broadcast policing shows "Cops" and "Live PD"were canceled, "Der Germinator" filmed a second season. But prospects for a third may have dimmed last week, when the Texas Legislature passed a bill that would make it illegal for law enforcement agencies to authorize reality television crews to film officers on duty.

"Policing is not entertainment," said James Talarico, the Democratic state representative who introduced the legislation. The office of Gov. Greg Abbott, a Republican, did not respond to requests for comment this week about whether he would sign the legislation.

Reality law enforcement shows, Mr. Talarico said, "rely on violent encounters between citizens and the police to boost their own ratings." He cited an investigation by The Austin American-Statesman, which reported last year that law enforcement officers in Williamson County, Texas, were more violent when the "Live PD" cameras were rolling.

The bill, which the Legislature passed with bipartisan support on May 13, is named after Javier Ambler II, a 40-year-old father of two who died in 2019 after Williamson County officers forcibly arrested him in front of a "Live PD" camera crew.

Mr. Ambler's sister, Kimberly Ambler-Jones, 39, said she believed that her brother would still be alive if the television crews had not been filming. "Because they had 'Live PD' there, it had to be hyped up," she said. "It had to be drama."

That show was taken off the air in June. So was "Cops," which had beamed arrests, confrontations and car chases to televisions across the United States for decades.

The cancellations came amid nationwide protests over the police killing of George Floyd in Minneapolis. They also followed years of campaigning by the racial justice organization Color of Change, which had been pushing networks to drop "Cops"since at least 2013.

Arisha Hatch, the organization's vice president and chief of campaigns, said the shows were one-sided and served as propaganda for law enforcement. "They violate the civil liberties of people who are forced to become the stars of the show," she said.

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